Superstore Sales Performance

Executive... | Discount Impact | Product... | Customer... | Regional... | Key Findings

Select all | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017

Region: All

Segment: All

Category: All

Reset

$2.3M Total Sales

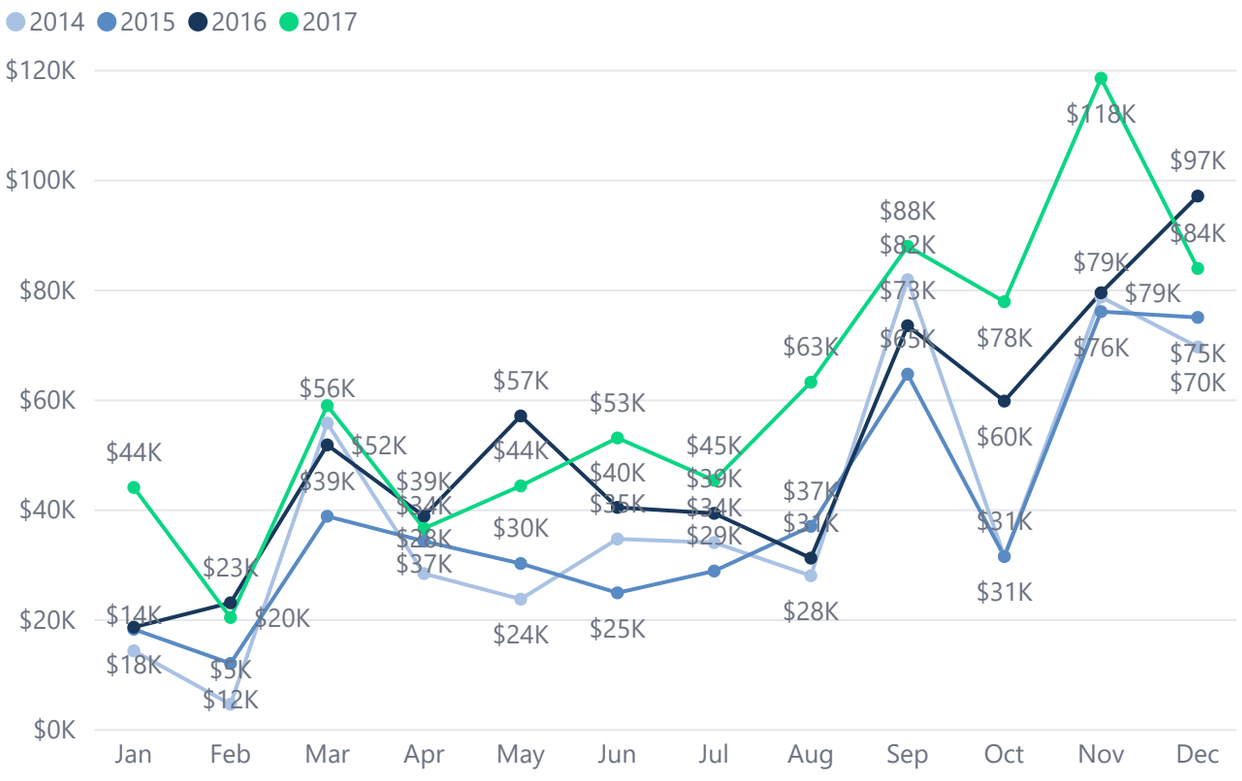
$286.4K Total Profit

12.5% Profit Margin %

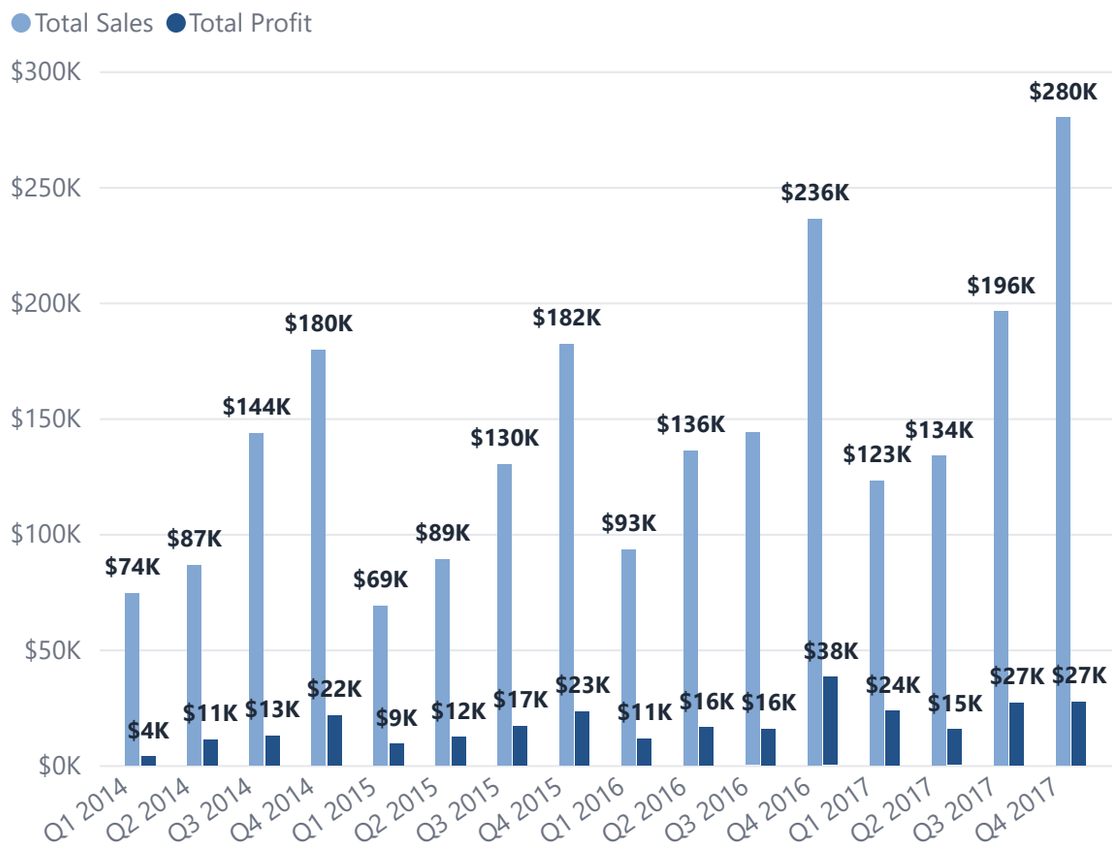
5,009 Orders

Monthly Sales by Year (2014–2017)

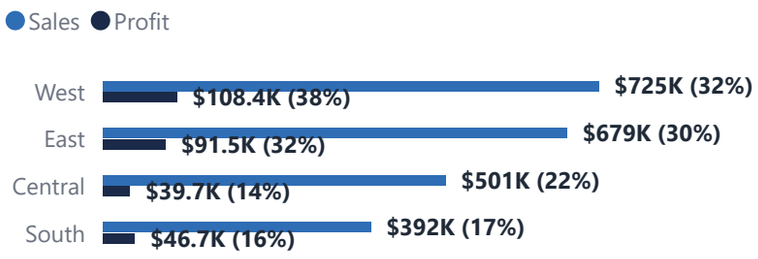
Same shape every year: low in January–February, peaks in September and November–December. All three customer segments show the same pattern: the peaks come from more customers ordering, most likely back-to-school and holiday shopping.



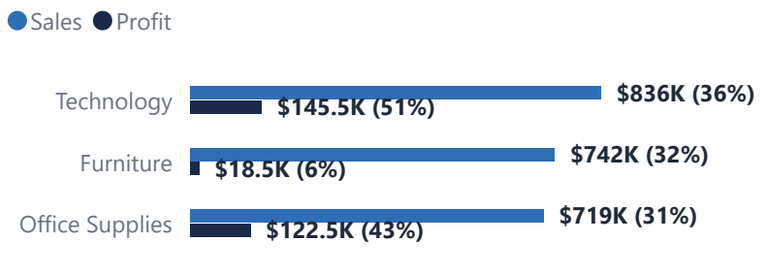
Sales and Profit by Quarter



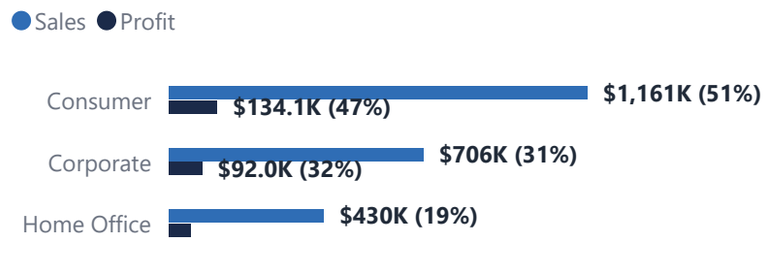
Sales and Profit by Region



Sales and Profit by Category



Sales and Profit by Segment



West: 32% of sales, 38% of profit. Central: 22% of sales, 14% of profit.

Furniture: 32% of sales, only 6% of profit.

Consumers bring about half of sales and profit.

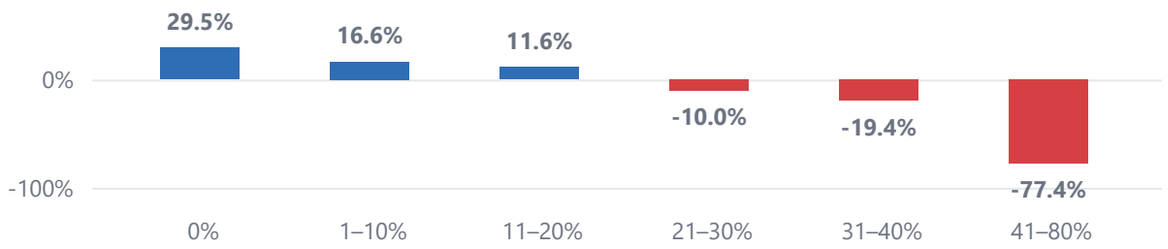
Superstore Sales Performance

Select all | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017

Region: All | Segment: All | Category: All | Sub-Category: All | Reset

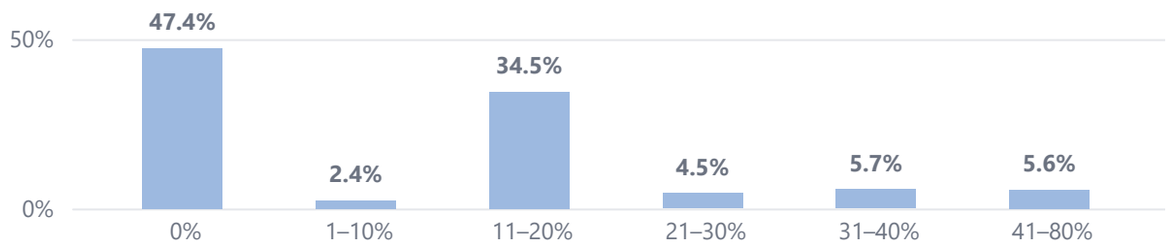
15.6%	15.8%	-$135.4K	$421.8K	12.5%	21.8%
Avg Discount %	Sales Share at >20% ...	Profit at >20% Disco...	Profit if >20% Off Br...	Profit Margin %	Margin % excl >20% ...

Profit Margin by Discount Level



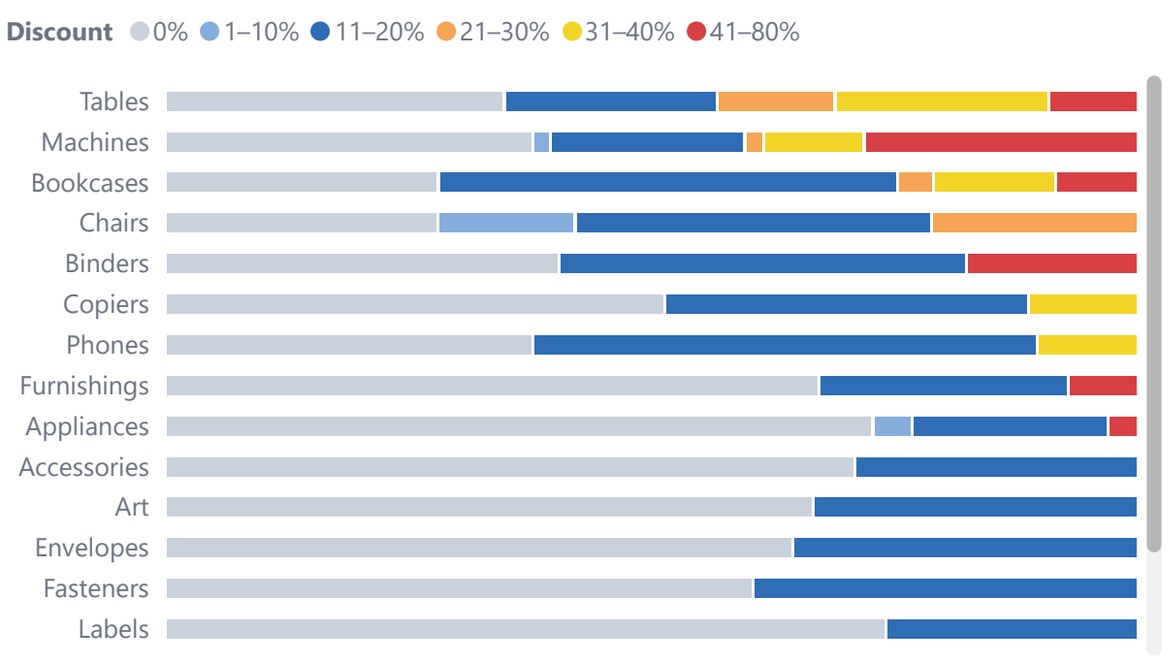
Over 20% off, the margin turns negative: 29.5% with no discount, −10% at 21–30%, −77% above 40%.

Share of Sales by Discount Level



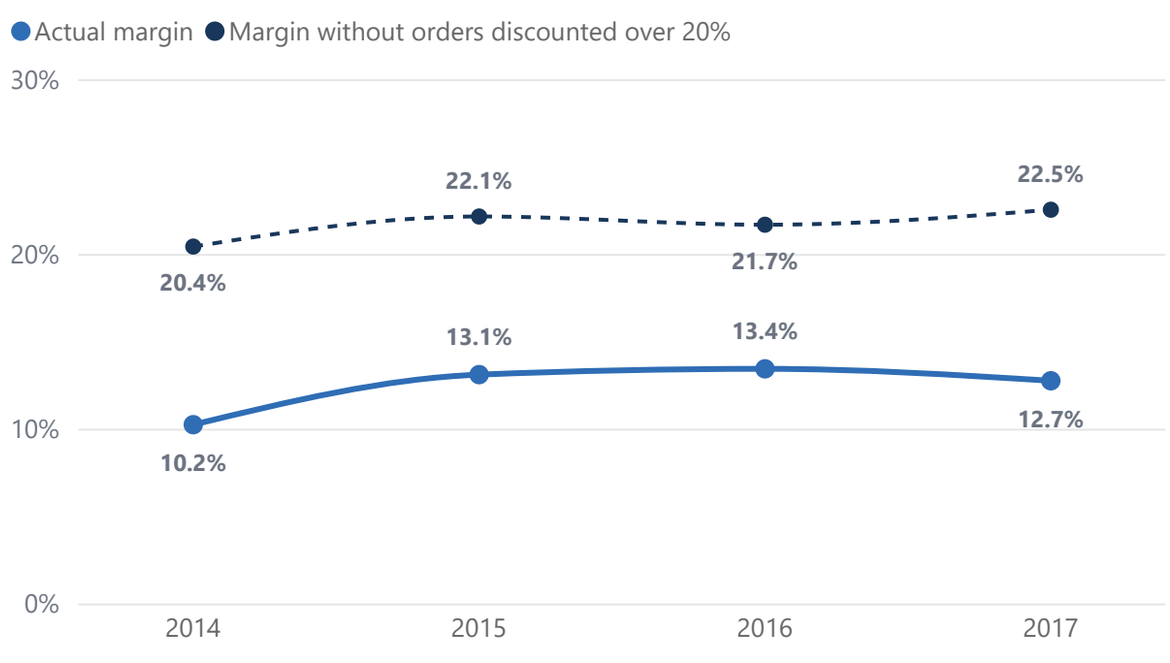
Each band above 20% is only ~5% of sales, but together they lose $135K.

How Each Sub-Category Is Discounted (2014–2017)



Most discounted: Tables (44% of sales above 20% off), Machines (41%), Bookcases (25%), Chairs (21%).

Profit Margin With and Without Deep Discounts (>20% Off)



Without orders over 20% off (dark line) the margin would be 20–23% a year instead of 10–13%.

Superstore Sales Performance

Select all | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017

Region: All | Segment: All | Category: All | Reset

$286.4K Total Profit

3 Loss-Making Sub-Categories

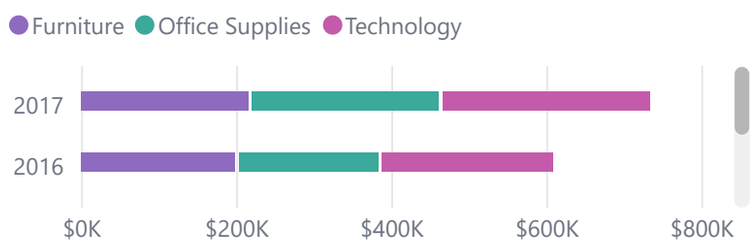
299 Loss-Making Products

12.5% Profit Margin %

Total Profit by Category and Sub-Category

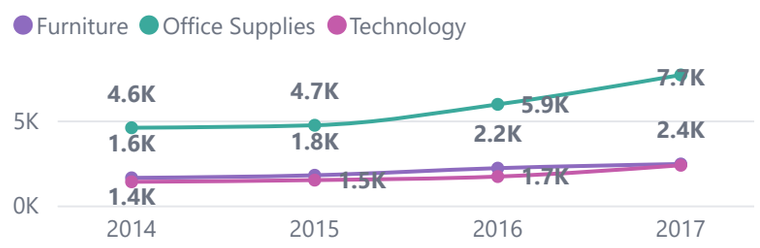
Category	Total Profit
Technology	**$145.5K**
Copiers	$55.6K
Phones	$44.5K
Accessories	$41.9K
Machines	$3.4K
Office Supplies	**$122.5K**
Paper	$34.1K
Binders	$30.2K
Storage	$21.3K
Appliances	$18.1K
Envelopes	$7.0K
Art	$6.5K
Labels	$5.5K
Fasteners	$0.9K
Supplies	-$1.2K
Furniture	**$18.5K**
Chairs	$26.6K
Furnishings	$13.1K
Bookcases	-$3.5K
Total	**$286.4K**

Sales by Category and Year



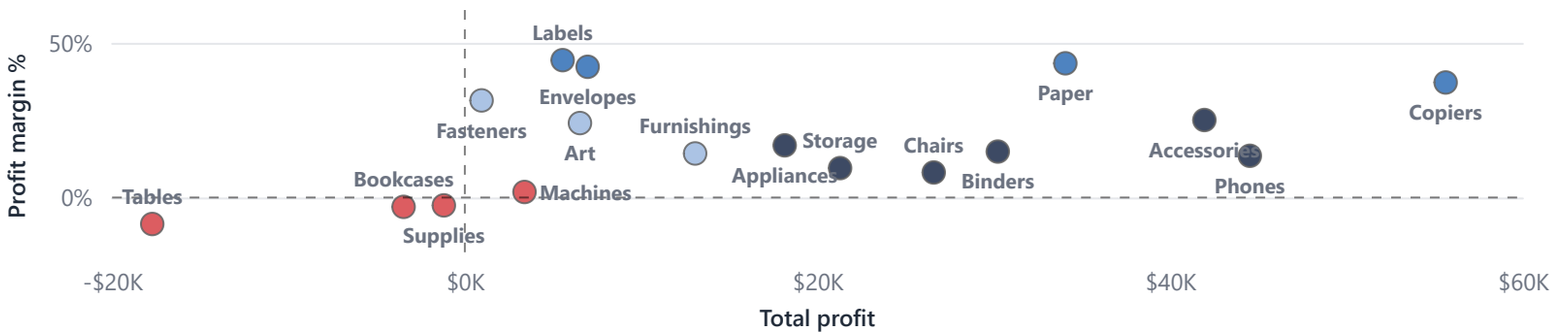
All categories grew; Office Supplies most ($152K → $246K).

Units Sold by Category and Year



Office Supplies sell 3x more units for similar sales: cheap items.

Sub-Categories by Profit and Margin (colour = profit group)



Right = more profit, up = higher margin. Tables, Bookcases and Supplies lose money; Copiers, Phones and Accessories lead.

5 Biggest Loss-Making Products (2014–2017)



Five products lost $22K: 3D and laser printers (Machines) and conference tables (Tables), the most discounted sub-categories.

Superstore Sales Performance

Select all | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017

Region: All

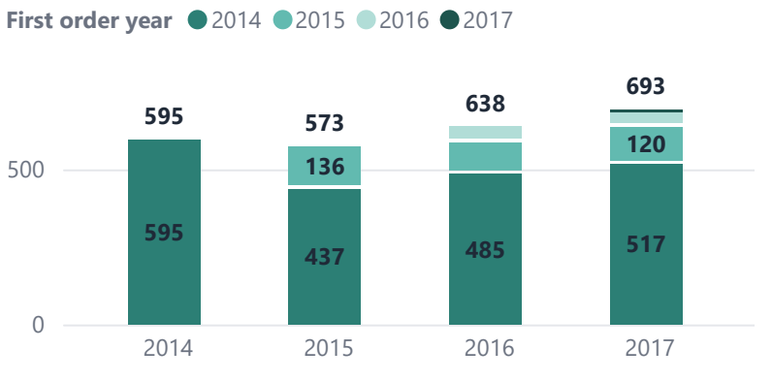
Segment: All

Category: All

Reset

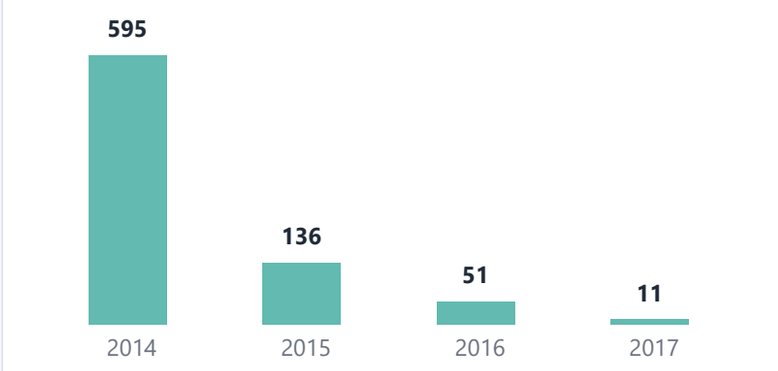
693	11	87.5%	2.4	$148.26
Active Customers (latest year)	New Customers (latest year)	Customer Retention % (late...	Orders per Customer (latest...	Median Order Value (latest ...

Active Customers per Year by First Order Year



Most customers stay: 517 of 2017's buyers first ordered in 2014.

New Customers per Year



New customers dried up: 595 in 2014, only 11 in 2017.

Customer Retention by First Order Year

Cohort Year	2014	2015	2016	2017
2014	100%	73%	82%	87%
2015		100%	75%	88%
2016			100%	88%
2017				100%

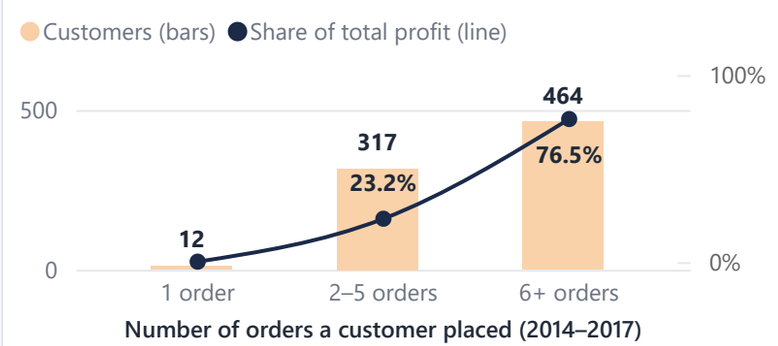
87–88% of the 2014 and 2015 customers still ordered in 2017.

Cumulative Share of Profit by Customer (2014–2017, all customers)



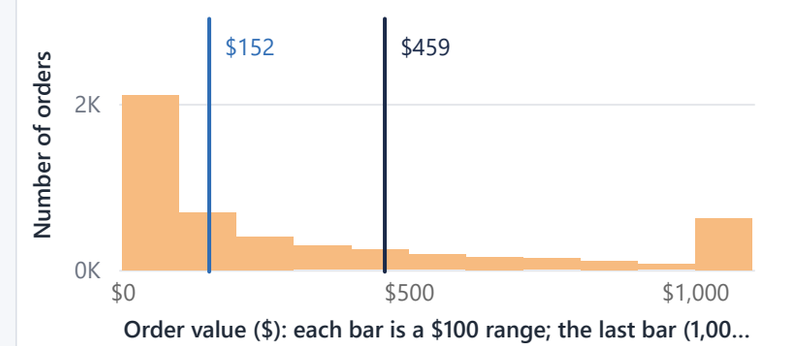
Top 20% of customers (orange line) bring 82% of profit; the bottom fifth lose money.

Customers by Number of Orders and Share of Profit (2014–2017)



464 customers with 6+ orders bring 76.5% of profit.

Order Value Distribution: Median vs Mean (2014–2017)



Half of orders are under $152 (blue line); big orders pull the mean to $459 (navy line).

Superstore Sales Performance

Select all | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017

Region: All

Segment: All

Category: All

Reset

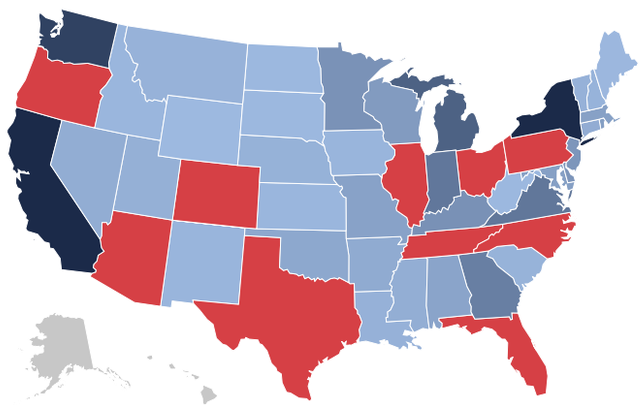
36.3%
Best State Margin (≥1% of sales)

-21.7%
Worst State Margin (≥1% of sales)

10
Loss-Making States

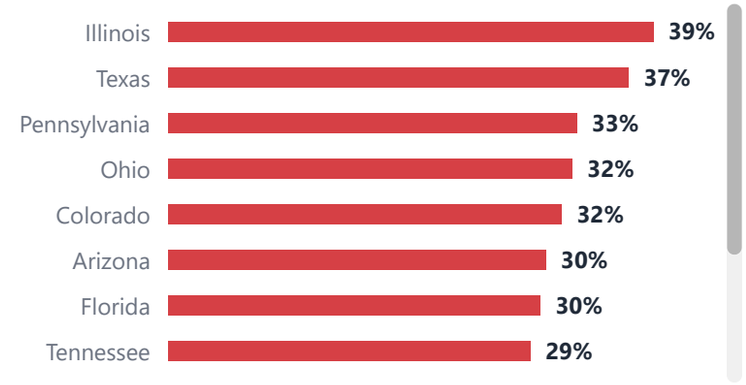
15.6%
Avg Discount %

Total Profit by State



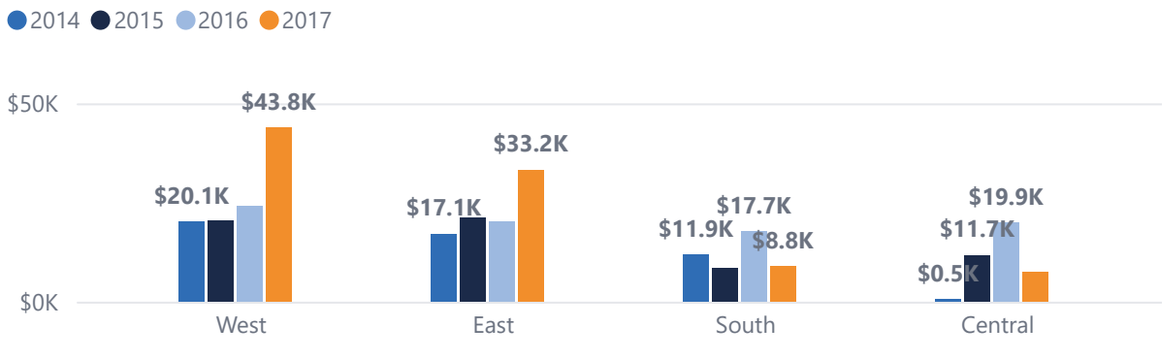
Red = loss, darker blue = more profit. Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois lose the most; California and New York earn the most.

States with the Highest Average Discount (red = loss-making)



All 10 loss-making states (red) average 28–39% discount; profitable ones stay at 20% or less.

Profit by Region and Year



West profit doubled ($20K → $44K); Central and South fell in 2017.

Profit by Region and Category

Region	Furniture	Office Supplies	Technology
⊞ Central	-$2.9K	$8.9K	$33.7K
⊞ East	$3.0K	$41.0K	$47.5K
⊞ South	$6.8K	$20.0K	$20.0K
⊞ West	$11.5K	$52.6K	$44.3K
Total	**$18.5K**	**$122.5K**	**$145.5K**

Technology leads in Central and East, Office Supplies in the West; Furniture loses money in Central.

Superstore Sales Performance

Key Findings & Recommendations

Sales grew 51% in four years and profit almost doubled, but big discounts cost almost a third of the profit we could have made.

$2.3M
Total Sales, 2014–2017

$286.4K
Total Profit, 2014–2017

12.5%
Profit Margin

Key Numbers by Year (2014–2017)

KPI	2014	2015	2016	2017	Δ 2017
Sales	$484,247	$470,533	$609,206	$733,215	+20%
Profit	$49,544	$61,619	$81,795	$93,439	+14%
Profit margin	10.2%	13.1%	13.4%	12.7%	-0.7 pp
Orders	969	1,038	1,315	1,687	+28%
Active customers	595	573	638	693	+9%
New customers	595	136	51	11	-78%
Average order value	$500	$453	$463	$435	-6%
Median order value	$155	$162	$146	$148	+2%

What we found

1. Big discounts lose money. When something is sold at more than 20% off, it loses money almost every time (97%). Those sales lost $135K. Without that loss, profit would have been $422K instead of $286K.

2. Ten states lose money, and all of them discount a lot. Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania, Illinois and six other states lost $98K together, with average discounts of 28–39%. Virginia gives no discounts and keeps 26 cents of every dollar.

3. Furniture sells well but earns little. It is a third of all sales but only 6% of profit. Tables and bookcases lose money.

4. A few expensive items cause big losses. Two 3D printers, a laser printer and two conference tables lost $22K, sold at 28–53% off.

5. A small group of customers brings most of the profit. The best 20% of customers bring 82% of profit. 155 customers cost more than they bring in.

6. Customers come back, but few new ones arrive. 87.5% of customers bought again in 2017, but only 11 new customers joined that year (136 in 2015).

7. Sales follow the calendar. September, November and December bring 43% of the year's sales; January and February only 7%. All three customer segments show the same pattern: the peaks come from more customers ordering, most likely back-to-school and holiday shopping.

8. End of 2017: more sales, less profit on each sale. Q4 2017 was the biggest quarter ever, but its margin fell to 9.8% (16.2% a year earlier).

What we suggest

1. Keep discounts at 20% or less. Anything bigger needs a manager's OK. At most $135K could be saved; the real figure depends on how many of those customers still buy at 20% off.

2. Check prices in the 10 loss-making states. Try a 20% limit in Texas first and compare it with Virginia and California.

3. Fix or drop the tables and bookcases that lose money. Check costs, stop deep discounts, and drop items that lose money at any price ($21K lost).

4. Set a minimum price for expensive machines. No more 40–50% off on 3D printers and laser printers (the five worst products lost $22K).

5. Look after the best customers. Give the top ~160 customers a personal contact, and review the deals with the 155 who lose us money.

6. Find new customers. Run campaigns in January and February, when it is quiet, and lead with cheap, high-margin items like paper and labels.

7. Get ready for the busy months. Plan stock and staff for September and November–December, and don't discount when people are already buying.